

Project XTC

Working Paper 006

Chapter 6 – Modes: One Controller, Many Personalities

One of the most confusing aspects of the X-Touch is that the same knob can perform completely different jobs from one moment to the next. This is not a design flaw; it is the fundamental idea behind the Mackie Control Universal (MCU) protocol.

What is a Mode?

A mode is simply a different interpretation of the same physical controls. The hardware never changes, but the software decides what those controls represent. DrivenByMoss makes extensive use of modes to give the X-Touch far more capability than eight faders and eight rotary encoders might suggest.

Typical Modes

Mixer – Faders control volume, V-Pots usually control pan.

Device – V-Pots edit parameters of the selected Bitwig device or plug-in.

Sends – Encoders adjust send levels instead of pan.

Browser – Encoders and buttons navigate Bitwig's browser and preset lists.

Why?

Think of the X-Touch as a skilled musician who can play several instruments. The hands are the same; only the role changes. Once you understand modes, it becomes natural to ask, 'What mode am I in?' before wondering why a control behaves differently.

Golden Habit

Whenever something unexpected happens: Check the selected track. Check the current mode. Those two checks solve the majority of day-to-day mysteries.

Exercise

Open a Bitwig project, enter Mixer mode and turn the first V-Pot. Observe its effect. Now switch to Device mode and turn the same V-Pot again. The physical movement is identical, but the meaning has changed completely. That is the essence of the X-Touch.

Looking Ahead

The next working paper will focus on the V-Pots themselves. We'll examine why they are the most versatile controls on the entire surface and how DrivenByMoss uses them across different modes.